

Giants' Relief Specialist McMahon Will Be Starting 20th Year In Game

By Tom Kane
Bee sports writer

CASA GRANDE, Ariz. — Relief specialist Don McMahon, at 40 the pitching patriarch of the Giants, will begin his 20th season in baseball this spring.

By this time relief pitching could be called old hat as far as McMahon is concerned. Almost all of his baseball life has been spent in the bull pen.

McMahon, who resides in Garden Grove, Calif., was assigned without warning to a relief assignment in only his second year in the sport by his Denver manager Andy Cohen, veteran and former major league coach.

"The Denver club knew I was going to have to fulfill a military commitment in the Army during the 1951 season," Don stated, "and one day in the spring Andy handed me a ball and told me to join the relief crew. And most of the time since that is where I have been."

McMahon was signed originally by the old Boston Braves organization and eventually helped the Milwaukee Braves to win two pennants as a rescue artist. His travels within the major leagues have taken him to Houston, Cleveland, Boston, Chicago, Detroit and finally to San Francisco on Aug. 8, 1969.

The 6-2 right-handed hurler has a lot of fond memories of the 1966 sea-

son when he was a member of one of the all-time best relief crews.

"I joined the White Sox in June and in relief the bull pen lost only one game the remainder of the season," Don recalled. "The bull pen included Bob Larker, Hoyt Wilhelm and Wilbur Wood. The one game we blew was against Detroit and we all had a hand in it. We had a three-run lead in the ninth inning and could not hold it.

"The White Sox were managed by Eddie Stanky and he was one of the best in determining when a pitcher should come out or stay in."

During the 1967 season Don won five games without a loss and pitched 92 innings in 52 games.

While with the old Atlanta club in 1954 McMahon came under the wing of veteran pitching coach Whit Wyatt, who counselled Don to become strictly a reliever.

"I could throw hard in those days and I did not have what could be called a good breaking pitch," Don stated. "I guess Wyatt figured I could go along for an inning or two with my fast ball. Later on I began using a breaking pitch.

"I have learned through the years that it takes just so long to get in condition and it does not do any good to rush things as I used to do in the past. I always have been

an advocate of pitchers running for longer distances than the outfielders and infielders. The infielders and outfielders have need for running short sprints with bursts of speed but the pitchers need to build up their strength and wind."

McMahon has been in the major leagues for 14 years and has 63 victo-

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